not many people do. If you wanted to secure a name in your phonebook, you'd probably use an app on your smartphone or an online web service to do the job. It is this very laziness that contributes to cryptography's effectiveness. The fewer the people who know about it (or are bothered to learn about it), the more successful you are at communicating messages without interception.

When you proceed towards learning about cryptography, you'll come across many terms. Terms such as keys, ciphers, encryption, codes, algorithm etc. Here we'll talk about them briefly so that you won't be intimidated by them. Also, you'll come across the jargon time and again while reading this little book so it's better to know them beforehand. Let's start with the simplest one.

Plaintext

All scrambled messages were once pieces of texts. These pieces which are yet to be scrambled are called 'plaintext' in cryptography vocabulary. Back when the science of scrambling messages started taking shape, it was usually text that needed to be sent securely. It's due to this reason that the original message which needs to be encrypted is called plaintext.

In the present context though, the word 'plaintext' doesn't justify all cases of encryption. We strive to keep all data communication secure and that surely doesn't include just text. Images, videos, programs and documents that don't fit into the 'simple text' mold are also transferred securely. Regardless of all this, you'll find numerous instances of data that needs to be encrypted being called plaintext.

Ciphertext

After you have scrambled the plaintext, you get an output which should pretty much look like mystical nonsense. This nonsense is called 'ciphertext'. It's also noteworthy that the algorithms to encrypt data are often called as 'ciphers'. Thus, the output they produce is called ciphertext.

Encoding & Decoding/ Encryption & Decryption

There's no shortage of examples where encryption' and 'decryption' are commonly mistaken for 'encoding' and 'decoding'. The reason for this is the similarities they share. Both transform data into another format and both are reversible (unlike 'hashing'). Though there are differences (Flip over to Chapter 3 for indepth information on the differences), all four are a part